

Jesus & Love

Receiving the love of Christ
and learning to live it



From the House of ChristGarden

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Reading this book

Each chapter pairs a Gospel-centered reflection with questions, a practical response, and prayer. Read the cited passages in your preferred Bible translation. The book paraphrases biblical ideas without presenting them as direct quotations. Prayers and illustrative examples are original devotional writing, not additional Scripture or messages claimed to have been personally spoken by God.

Notice the setting of each passage. Ask what the text reveals about Jesus before moving to a personal application. References to other biblical books provide supporting reflection and are identified by book, chapter, and verse.

You can read individually or with a small group. Allow disagreement and questions to be discussed respectfully. No exercise requires personal disclosure. When a passage raises painful memories, pause if needed and seek trustworthy support. Devotional reading can accompany pastoral or professional care; it does not replace help that a situation requires.

Introduction

Knowing love by looking at Jesus

The word love can become so familiar that we stop asking what it means. It may describe affection, approval, attraction, loyalty, or the wish that another person would never be disappointed. These meanings sometimes overlap. They can also conflict. A person may speak warmly while avoiding responsibility, or tell a difficult truth with genuine care. We need more than the word itself to recognize love.

Christian faith turns our attention to Jesus. In *John 1:14-18*, the Gospel describes the Word becoming flesh and making God known. This is the starting point of the book: we learn about divine love by attending to Christ's life, words, death, and resurrection. His love gives shape to our understanding rather than simply confirming whatever we already prefer.

The following chapters move through encounters and teachings in the Gospels. We will consider the welcome Jesus describes, the compassion he practices, and the truth he refuses to conceal. We will reflect on the cross and resurrection, then ask how prayer and ordinary conduct can become a response to the love we receive.

The book also makes room for protection. Asking God to keep us safe is a natural expression of trust. Yet Jesus does not teach that faithful people will never suffer. Our prayers can ask for rescue, wisdom, strength, and companionship without making an outcome the measure of God's love. There is room to pray with confidence in his character while admitting uncertainty about circumstances.

You do not need to produce a particular emotion while reading. Some passages may comfort you; others may challenge or puzzle you. Stay attentive. Bring your questions to God and, where helpful, to a trusted Christian community. The aim is a growing knowledge of Christ that reaches the way you treat people, including the person you are when no one else is watching.

1 Love that comes near

The meaning of God entering human life

There is a difference between receiving advice from a distance and being accompanied by someone willing to enter your circumstances. A visitor who notices what the day actually requires may offer more comfort than a person with an immediate explanation for everything. Presence cannot solve every difficulty, but it tells us that our life is worth attending to.

John 1:1-18 presents something deeper than an illustration of good companionship. The Word who is with God and is God becomes flesh. Christian faith understands the incarnation as God's self-disclosure in Jesus Christ. Divine love is made known within human life, with its physical needs, relationships, and vulnerability. We are invited to know God through the Son rather than imagining him only from a distance.

This changes the way we regard ordinary experience. Hunger, tiredness, work, and tears are not beneath God's attention. The Gospels show Jesus inhabiting a real human life. When you bring him a small concern, you are not interrupting his interest in more impressive matters. A prayer about a difficult conversation or an exhausting day can be a truthful act of trust.

At the same time, coming near involves attention on our part. It is possible to move through a day while remaining far from everyone in it. We hear words without listening and notice needs only when they inconvenience us. Reflecting on Christ's nearness can challenge us to enter another person's circumstances more patiently. Before giving advice, ask what their day has actually been like.

You do not have to imitate the incarnation as though you could become someone else's savior. You are a limited person who can offer limited care. **But you can let the love revealed in Christ guide your presence.** A careful question, an unhurried meal, or a practical act of help can communicate that another person's life deserves more than hurried conclusions.

Receiving and offering presence

Attend to the ordinary

What part of your daily life do you rarely bring to God because it seems too small? Consider a task, a worry, or a recurring conversation. What would it mean to pray about it honestly rather than wait for a crisis?

Who in your life receives your advice more often than your attention? Think about whether you understand the circumstances behind their concern. A slower question may be more useful than another quick solution.

One faithful response

Choose an ordinary activity and begin it with a brief prayer for attentiveness. During one conversation, put aside avoidable distractions and ask a genuine follow-up question. Listen to the answer without turning the conversation immediately toward your own experience. Let the other person remain the subject for a little longer.

A prayer for attentive faith

Lord Jesus, thank you for entering human life and making the Father known. Help me receive your nearness without pretending that I must become impressive before I pray. I bring you the ordinary responsibilities and concerns of this day. Teach me to live them with attention and trust.

Father, protect me from a hurried way of loving that gives answers before it understands. Help me notice the person behind the request. Give me wisdom about what I can offer and humility about what I cannot. Let my presence become more patient, my questions more honest, and my care more responsive to the life actually before me. Amen.